The director (establishment) then sought my views on the subject. Conscious of the fact that what the director had asked my colleague was a valid question (as to whether there was really a Khalistan issue at all), I defended my proposal. He was not convinced. Finally, I told him that the difference between the MEA and R&AW was, 'Whereas MEA comes to know about the problem when it starts appearing in the media, the R&AW becomes aware of the same at the conceptual stage itself.' Naturally, he did not appreciate my 'cheeky' answer. I told him that if he was confident there was no such problem and there was no chance of its emergence in the near future, he should write so on the file and I would gladly take my officer back.

Obviously, he could not do that as he was aware of the special circumstances under which those posts were sanctioned. Later I learnt that there was a feeling in the MEA at that time that the R&AW was creating additional posts in Indian missions abroad taking full advantage of the 'non-existent' Khalistan issue. Much later, I apologized to the officer concerned for that cheeky answer. But little did I know at that time that the fast-moving developments resulting from Op-2 would soon render my proposals prophetic.

Gauging the mood of the Sikh diaspora

Meanwhile, it appeared the 1 Akbar Road group, including Indira Gandhi, were getting anxious to know about the impact of Op-2 on the Sikh diaspora, especially in the US and Canada. As the R&AW had still not managed to fill the newly sanctioned posts, and as the few officers who were already posted there were not in a position to cover large and distant areas of the US and Canada, Suntook asked me to visit those countries for about ten days. My brief was to ascertain the diaspora's views on the developments taking place in Punjab and suggest measures to improve the situation. I left for Ottawa, on or around 15 December 1981, arrived the next day and spent couple of days there. I left for Vancouver on 18 December before moving to Los Angeles on 22 December, from where I left for Tokyo on 24 December en route to India.